



Matteo Merler

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Summary

I am a researcher at the FBK NLP in Trento, Italy. This Fall, I will start my PhD at the Bethge Lab in Tübingen, Germany, as an ELLIS PhD Student and as part of the International Max Planck Research School for Intelligent Systems (IMPRS-IS). I also work with Tom Silver's group for robotics and planning in Princeton, US. Previously, I obtained my MSc degree in Machine Learning, Data Science and Artificial Intelligence from Aalto University in Helsinki, Finland.

I want to build autonomous AI agents that learn from experience and adapt quickly to novel situations. I am interested in how agents turn prior knowledge and experience into effective behavior, and what they do when their existing knowledge or strategies are no longer sufficient.

My recent work explores executable world models and policies: using language models to construct programs that can be tested, revised, and reused to plan and act. I am particularly interested in how agents recognize the limits of these solutions, recover from unexpected situations, and retain what they learn. I work with both simulated games and real-world robotics as environments for agents to learn and adapt in. I am also curious about the connections between AI and cognitive science, and how insights from human cognition can inform the development of more intelligent agents.

You can also see what I am up to right now.

Education

M.Sc. Aalto University [↗](#), Machine Learning, Data Science and Artificial Intelligence Sept 2022 – Sept 2024

- Graduated with honors, with a **final grade of 5.0/5.0** and a **GPA of 5.0/5.0**.
- **Thesis** [↗](#): **Generating Code World Models with Large Language Models Guided by Monte Carlo Tree Search**, supervised by Prof. Pekka Marttinen, published at NeurIPS 2024.
- Thesis awarded as one of the three **best MSc theses of 2024** at the School of Science.
- Received the Dean's Scholarship for outstanding academic performance.

B.Sc. University of Trento [↗](#), Computer Science Sept 2019 – July 2022

- Graduated with a **final grade of 110/110 cum laude (with honors)** and a **GPA of 28.46/30**.
- Thesis: **Route Optimization for Indoor Spaces**, supervised by Prof. Alberto Montresor (in Italian).

H.S. Liceo Scientifico Leonardo da Vinci [↗](#), Liceo Scientifico (Italian Scientific High School Diploma) Sept 2014 – July 2019

- Graduated with a **final grade of 100/100**.

Experience

Researcher, Fondazione Bruno Kessler [↗](#) Trento, Italy
Working as a pre-doctoral researcher ("Researcher 4 contract") in the **Natural Language Processing Lab** [↗](#) under the supervision of Bernardo Magnini. Jan 2025 – present

- Lead researcher on FBK's side of a joint project on **planning with Vision-Language Models** (with Aalto University), under resubmission.

- Led a second project on **selectively integrating VLM guidance with model-free Reinforcement Learning** based on the agent's own uncertainty, with a preliminary version accepted at the CAIPI workshop at ECAI 2025 and a full paper in preparation.
- Participating on private research for collaborations with companies.
- Contributing to the draft of a **Horizon Europe funding proposal**, leading the lab's team for Language and Reinforcement Learning.
- Active participation to the research group's scientific activities, including monthly meetings and collaborative discussions.

Research Assistant, [Aalto University](#) [↗](#)

Helsinki, Finland

MSc Thesis worker in the [Foundation Models for Language and Reinforcement Learning](#) [↗](#) (Larel) group, supervised by Prof. Pekka Marttinen. Aug 2024 – Sept 2024

- Conducted a research project on **Symbolic Regression with Large Language Models**, presented at the ACL Student Research Workshop.
- Co-led a research project on **Code World Models** with PhD candidate Nicola Dainese, forming the basis of my Master's Thesis, accepted at NeurIPS 2024.
- Started a project on **planning with Vision-Language Models**, later continued by both Aalto University and my current group at FBK.
- Regularly attended lab meetings and participated in broader academic activities, including the Seminar on Large Language Models.

Internship, [ThinkIN](#) [↗](#)

Trento, Italy

Worked as a software developer intern in collaboration with the University of Trento. Feb 2022 – June 2022

- Designed and built a prototype for an indoor navigation system specifically targeted for supermarkets, to be used with the company's own location tracking system.

Publications

[QVal: Cheaply Evaluating Dense Supervision Signals for Long-Horizon LLM Agents](#) [↗](#)

Dec 2026

Sergio Hernández-Gutiérrez, **Matteo Merler**[†], Ilze Amanda Auzina[†], Joschka Strüber, Ameya Prabhu, Matthias Bethge

Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems 39 (NeurIPS 2026), Evaluations and Datasets Track

[Selective Agent Guidance via Entropy: Learning Autonomous Policies from Imperfect VLM Teachers](#) [↗](#)

Oct 2026

Giovanni Bonetta[†], **Matteo Merler**[†], Davide Zago, Rossella Cancelliere, Bernardo Magnini

Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: EMNLP 2026

[DecSelfMask: Leveraging Unlabeled Text via Self-Relevance-Guided Masking for Decoder-Only Classification](#) [↗](#)

Oct 2026

Pietro Ferrazzi, **Matteo Merler**, Giovanni Bonetta, Alberto Lavelli, Bernardo Magnini

Proceedings of the 2026 Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing (EMNLP 2026)

[ViPlan: A Benchmark for Visual Planning with Symbolic Predicates and Vision-Language Models](#) [↗](#)

Oct 2026

Matteo Merler[†], Nicola Dainese[†], Minttu Alakuijala, Giovanni Bonetta, Pietro Ferrazzi, Yu Tian, Bernardo Magnini, Pekka Marttinen

Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: EMNLP 2026

EMPIRIC: Experiment-Driven Learning of Residual World Models for Robot Planning ↗	Sept 2026
Yichao Liang, Amber Li, Dat Nguyen [†] , Emily Bunnapradist [†] , Michelangelo Naim [†] , Sreela Kodali [†] , Matteo Merler , Bowen Li, Kiran Gopinathan, Yiyun Liu, Nikhil Pimpalkhare, Joshua B. Tenenbaum, Adrian Weller, Zenna Tavares, Tom Silver, Kevin Ellis <i>arXiv preprint</i>	
Coding Agents for Generalized Task and Motion Planning Problems ↗	Sept 2026
Matteo Merler , Bowen Li, Josh Roy, Yichao Liang, Qianwei Wang, Yixuan Huang, Tom Silver <i>arXiv preprint</i>	
Guiding Reinforcement Learning with Selective Vision-Language Model Supervision ↗	Oct 2025
Matteo Merler , Giovanni Bonetta, Bernardo Magnini <i>ECAI Workshop on AI-based Planning for Complex Real-World Applications (CAIPI'25)</i>	
Generating Code World Models with Large Language Models Guided by Monte Carlo Tree Search ↗	Dec 2024
Nicola Daineset [†] , Matteo Merler [†] , Minttu Alakuijala, Pekka Marttinen <i>Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems 37 (NeurIPS 2024)</i>	
In-Context Symbolic Regression: Leveraging Large Language Models for Function Discovery ↗	Aug 2024
Matteo Merler [†] , Katsiaryna Haitsiukevich [†] , Nicola Daineset [†] , Pekka Marttinen <i>Proceedings of the 62nd Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics, Volume 4: Student Research Workshop (ACL 2024 SRW)</i>	

[†] denotes equal contribution

Additional Experience and Awards

Master's Thesis Award [↗](#): My Master's Thesis was awarded as one of the three best MSc theses of 2024 at the School of Science.

Volunteer

Volunteer , Libera Associazioni Nomi e Numeri Contro le Mafie ↗	Calabria, Italy July 2017 – July 2017
I participated in a volunteering camp experience in southern Italy where we cultivated the fields of mafia-confiscated houses for the Libera association, while also taking part in various activities on the territory and listening to testimonies from victims and policemen.	
Volunteer , Associazione Volontaria "Per un Mondo Migliore" ↗	Rijeka, Croatia Aug 2018 – Aug 2018
I participated in a volunteering camp experience in Rijeka, Croatia where we helped different families and associations in need around the city and in mainland Croatia while living together in a shared home.	

Languages

Italian: Native | **English:** C2 (Near-native proficiency) | **German:** A2 (Basic)